Key informants shared they are seeing more people that are disconnected from the community and disengaged. They are also seeing bullying in schools, where children are made to feel alone and scared.

Because many people in Valdez are self-reliant and independent, they may be hesitant to reach out for help, particularly when it relates to behavioral health needs. They key is social connection and community engagement, showing up day-to-day, not only in times of disaster, to care for one another.

> *"Okay, I would say unmet health needs would be social connection, by far, is the number one. … [Community members] understand that we're all on the island at the end of the road, we're going to help each other, but not in a way like showing up every day. I guess I would say they would climb the mountain for someone, but they wouldn't do the dishes."—Key Informant*

Affordable childcare and preschools

Most key informants discussed the lack of childcare in Valdez and emphasized it is an urgent issue and one that a task force is currently working on addressing.

> *"Childcare is an issue, a huge issue. I know we are not the only ones, but it seems to be a greater issue here."—Key Informant*

There are currently no childcare centers in Valdez.

> *"We have, at this point, no access to childcare from a childcare center."—Key Informant*

Key informants shared affordable childcare is important for a variety of reasons, including that it is critical for early development and school readiness. Providing care for young children goes beyond babysitting, but really entails nurturing their development. They identified early education as a long-term investment in children and emphasized the importance of supporting children zero to three, in particular.

> *"[Childcare is] education. There's [sic] things you can do with these children that help develop their brains and to help them, prepare them better for school even at an early age, and cope, and have proper nutrition and things like that."—Key Informant*

> *"We had this little seminar here in town on resilience, and it talked about the critical need for zero to three [early education]. Working with infants, toddlers, et cetera to address social determinants of health at an early age and the impact that has on their lifetime health benefits."—Key Informant*

> *"I do think some kind of coordinated effort to tackle childcare and early education would pay dividends eventually."—Key Informant*